

troubled, situation: "I mind my own business, I bother nobody," he says, "and what do I get? Trouble."

Toward realism

The Bicycle Thief is often considered the high point of Italian neorealism. In cinema, the neorealist movement was a reaction against the so-called white telephone Italian movies of the 1930s, which depicted the frivolous lives of the rich, characterized by

Bruno watches his father anxiously as he sits, despondent, on the roadside, all hopes of a new life shattered.

**“You live and you suffer.
To hell with it. You want a pizza?”**

Antonio Ricci / *The Bicycle Thief*

the white telephones seen in their gilded homes—movies such as *I Will Love You Always* (*T'amerò sempre*, 1933), that, while not overt tools of propaganda, portrayed an image of prosperity that implicitly endorsed Italy's Fascist regime.

It was not only in Italy that filmmakers tried to break from the milieu of high society. Chaplin

attempted it in *Modern Times* (1936) in Hollywood. But Italian neorealists went further. They did not simply focus on the poor; they also wanted to make movies in a new way that would show the reality of people's lives as they were lived.

Neorealism took the director's camera away from the set and out onto location. The goal was to

